...or use a soft brush over your work between grits to improve the finish

HEALTH AND SAFETY

It goes almost without saying, that while sanding, you need to protect yourself from the dust. I would suggest that the whole turning process produces dust, not just the sanding part, so protection should be worn throughout the process ideally, but when sanding it becomes very apparent. In my workshop, I wear an air fed, full face respirator which protects me from flying shavings and dust. I also have an extractor with a hose that can be positioned close to the source of the dust and an air filter running at all times when I'm in the workshop. The combination of these three protects me as much as possible can from the harmful effects of working with wood. Exposure to dust, over time, can lead to allergic reactions and respiratory problems or worse, which I simply don't want. Please protect yourself.

Completed wenge handles, sanded to 600 grit: finishing in line with the grain, shows no sanding marks

SANDING DIFFICULT AREAS

While most work can be accessed easily by simply folding or rolling the abrasive to suit the shape of the work, there are times when special measures need to be taken. For example, the corners of a square bowl are potentially difficult, if not downright dangerous to sand with the lathe spinning. The picture below shows a square platter that has been turned. Inside the area defined by the dark pencil ring, it is easy to sand by power or hand, obviously being careful not to encroach on the outer edge or corner area. The corner sections past the marked ring are the danger zones and as such should only really be tackled with the lathe stationary, using a cork block with an abrasive or a power drill with a sanding arbour or a random orbital sander as appropriate. Once sanded, clean up all the edges.

Some boxes have shapes that can be difficult to reach, such as heart-shaped or ginger jar style boxes, where you need to sand around a rim. In these cases, great care needs to be taken: it is not wholly safe to hold the abrasive with your fingers and stick your fingers in the opening hole. You will run the risk of getting caught with the abrasive wrapping around your fingers, which can cause a nasty injury. Using a single finger is always safer than two, but again, sanding with the lathe off may be the safest option, especially on deep undercuts. Other options include using forceps to hold the abrasive, or fastening the abrasive or a velcro ball onto the end of a stick, to work into areas where fingers can't reach or would be unsafe. Depending on the shape of the item being sanded, you should consider supporting the forceps or sanding stick on the rest while sanding.

Remember, if using forceps to sand, never stick your fingers through the finger holes while sanding. ●

Sanding square edged bowls should be done with the lathe stationary

Forceps, a sanding stick or ball allow access to difficult shapes safely

Never hold forceps by the finger holes just in case they catch

WT_290_27_31_RICHARD_FINDLEY_TECH_bdVSmbRFsd.indd 31 03/02/2016 12:57